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Surfing Whale

The rules this site already follows, written down — so the next decision can be made without guessing, and so a decision that breaks one of them breaks it *on purpose*.

Every number here was taken, not chosen.

The colours are read out of `app/globals.css` when this book is built. The faces are the same `.woff2` files the site serves. The contrast ratios are computed here, not quoted from memory. If a value in this book and a value in the code disagree, the code is right and this book is stale — rebuild it with `node scripts/build-brand-book.mjs`.

Four layers, in order of what settles first

A says why the site exists and **B** says how it talks; both are quoted from what he has already written. **C** is how it looks and behaves, read out of the code. **D** is what keeps the three from drifting. A decision taken at a lower letter may not contradict a higher one.

A Foundation

Why this exists · what it is and is not · who it is for · personality

B Verbal identity

How it speaks · do and do not · names and numbers

C Design system

The five decisions · colour · type · space · surface · parts · motion · pictures · refusals

D Governance

What is checked automatically · colophon

The site is a logbook kept in the open: work, photographs and notes, dated and numbered, by someone moving into data analysis from accounting. It is not a job application and must never read as one.

It is already written. This page only quotes it.

A brand foundation composed by somebody else about somebody else is a guess with a letterhead. This one does not need writing: the statement exists in the repository, in his words, and the site is built on it. Everything below is lifted from `app/data/testament.ts` when this book is built.

THE PURPOSE, IN ONE SENTENCE

“It is a place where I can leave traces of the things I chose to care about.”

THE BELIEF THE WHOLE ARCHIVE RESTS ON

“A thing does not need to be impressive to deserve a place in the archive.”

THE TENSION IT REFUSES TO HIDE

“I still want recognition. ... But I do not want attention to become the authority that decides whether something mattered. I want meaning to exist before the audience arrives.”

This is the sentence that governs more of the site than any design rule: it is why there is no availability notice, no call to action on the first screen, and no counter that exists to look impressive.

“It is not only a portfolio and it is not only an archive.”

IT IS

- A logbook kept in the open: dated, numbered, counted
- A record that something was chosen and cared about
- Two sides of one person — the data and the photographs
- Allowed to hold things that are unfinished or small

IT IS NOT

- A job application, or a site arranged around one
 - A portfolio of only the impressive things
 - A claim to be a photographer, or a programmer
 - A place where reach decides whether something mattered
-

Why the two halves are one site

“I can choose photography without becoming a photographer. I can learn to code without becoming a programmer.”

That is the argument the mode switch makes. *Data* and *Photographs* are two things one person cares about, not two careers being advertised — which is why they share a page, a palette and a voice, and why neither is a sub-site of the other.

A stranger, three paragraphs in, deciding whether to keep reading.

The site makes one assumption about its reader and it is visible in every section note: that they arrived without context, owe nothing, and will leave the moment it asks for something before it has shown anything.

WHAT THE COPY ALREADY ASSUMES

They do not know who he is

The work is shown before the name, and the name carries a trade beside it.

They might disagree

“If something here is useful, wrong, or worth arguing about — say so. I answer everything.”

They might only want one thing

Every section says what it is in a note, so any of them can be the only one read.

They owe nothing

No sign-up, no gate on the work, no notice asking for an opportunity.

Open, and his to answer: whether there is a narrower reader than “a stranger” — a hiring manager, a fellow analyst, a friend — that the site should be arranged around. It is not written here because it has not been decided, and guessing it would put a stranger’s assumptions into his book.

Five traits, each with the evidence that it is true.

Not adjectives chosen because they sound good. Each one is a pattern already visible in the site or in the way it was built.

(1) **Plain** Says the thing and stops.

Error messages read “Could not save that. Try again in a moment.” — no apology, no blame, what to do next.

(2) **Specific** Prefers a number to an adjective.

“15 minutes to coffee”, ‘26, Plate 01, 4.52:1. Never “beautifully crafted”.

(3) **Unhurried** Does not chase.

No call to action on the first screen. The ways to reach him are at the end, where someone who wants them will be.

(4) **Self-correcting** Says when it was wrong.

The PRD records every over-count and every failed check by name, including the ones nobody would have found.

(5) **Unimpressed by itself** Refuses the flourish that would flatter it.

No superlatives, nothing “featured”, and a counter that says how many rather than how good.

First person, past tense, no adjectives doing a number's job.

The site already has a voice and it is consistent enough to write down. Every rule below is taken from copy that is live.

Write as a person, not as a site

"I answer everything." — not "All enquiries are responded to."

Say what happened, not what it proves

"The finding was not the coffee — it was that almost every branch sits on a road you drive."

Let the number carry the claim

"07 entries", "15 minutes to coffee", "4.52:1". An adjective standing where a figure belongs is a hole in the argument.

Never promise what has not happened

A note shows "once I have read them", not "we will get back to you shortly".

Admit the limit in the same breath

"A picture of a map is not a map." The caption says what the thing is not.

Short sentences when it matters

The heaviest lines on the site are the shortest ones.

Tone, by situation

Showing work	flat, specific, no selling
Asking for something	once, with a reason, never twice
Something broke	what failed, what to do, no apology
Writing about himself	past tense, no claim to a title

Taken from live copy, not invented for the example.

WRITTEN	NOT WRITTEN
— “Anyone can write in here — a hello, a question, a correction.”	— “We’d love to hear from you!”
— “Could not reach the server.”	— “Oops! Something went wrong.”
— “Add your name so I know who stopped by.”	— “Name is required”
— “Learning it in the open”	— “Passionate about data”
— “Read how it was made”	— “Learn more”
— “It will show up below once I have had a look.”	— “Thanks! We’ll be in touch soon.”

Names and numbers

The site	Surfing Whale — two words
The person	Muhammad Fauzy; Fauzy after first use
A year beside a name	’26, never 2026
A counter	01, zero-padded, mono
A plate or an entry	Plate 01 — what it shows

Sentence case everywhere except the label alphabet, which is uppercase by specification.
Headings never take a full stop; a standfirst does.

Five decisions. Everything else follows.

(1) The work comes before the person

The first screen a stranger reaches shows what was made, not who made it. The name is the label on the plate. This is why the hero is a photograph with a card under it and not a wordmark.

(2) It is a logbook, not a portfolio

Things are dated, numbered and kept — '01, Plate 01, Note 02, Entry 07. Nothing is “featured”. The counter is the claim: it says people were here, work was done, time passed.

(3) Separation is drawn with rules

A hairline, not a shadow; a border, not a card. Depth is reserved for things that are genuinely above other things — a dialog, a floating prompt. A page of soft-shadowed boxes is the look this site exists to not have.

(4) One alphabet for labels, one for figures

11px uppercase at 0.14em tracking for every label, anywhere. Mono tabular for every number, anywhere. A second voice for either is a drift, not a decision.

(5) The measurement is the finding

Claims about this site are checked by scripts in /scripts and reported as numbers. Where something cannot be measured here, it is stated as a platform rule and labelled as one, never dressed up as a test.

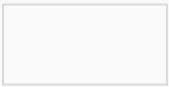
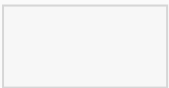
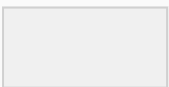
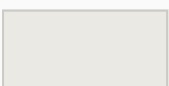
Paper and ink, and one blue that is only ever the whale.

There is no brand colour on this site in the usual sense. The page is paper, the type is ink at five strengths, and the only chroma on a default screen is the logo. Colour arrives in the work — a map, a photograph — and the page stays out of its way.

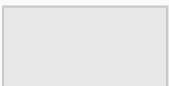
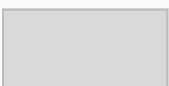
INK

	<code>--fg</code>	<code>#111111</code>	Headings, the name, any figure that must be read first.
	<code>--fg-secondary</code>	<code>rgba(17, 17, 17, 0.75)</code>	Rarely. Standfirsts and pull quotes.
	<code>--fg-muted</code>	<code>rgba(17, 17, 17, 0.58)</code>	Counters, years, the second half of a label pair.
	<code>--fg-body</code>	<code>#6f6f6f</code>	Running copy. Every paragraph on the site.
	<code>--fg-label</code>	<code>#76736f</code>	The label alphabet — section labels, plate notes, kickers.
	<code>--brand-ink</code>	<code>#2154a4</code>	The whale. The logo and nothing else.

SURFACE

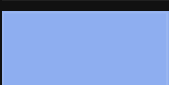
	<code>--bg</code>	<code>#fafafa</code>	The page.
	<code>--bg-subtle</code>	<code>#f7f7f7</code>	A band that needs to separate without becoming a panel.
	<code>--bg-muted</code>	<code>#f0f0f0</code>	An image placeholder before the image arrives.
	<code>--doc</code>	<code>#ffffff</code>	Paper — a document handed to you, whiter than the page.
	<code>--folder</code>	<code>#ebe9e4</code>	The case folder. Warm, so it does not vanish into the page.

LINE

	<code>--border</code>	<code>rgba(17, 17, 17, 0.08)</code>	Every hairline. The site's default way of separating things.
	<code>--border-strong</code>	<code>rgba(17, 17, 17, 0.14)</code>	A rule that has to be seen from across the page.

The dark theme is not the light one inverted.

Ink goes to #f0f0f0 rather than white, the page to #111111 rather than black, and the muted step is *raised* — 0.49 alpha against light mode’s 0.58 — because the same alpha on a dark ground reads as a different weight. Both themes are measured; neither is assumed.

	--fg	#f0f0f0
	--fg-secondary	rgba(240, 240, 240, 0.75)
	--fg-muted	rgba(240, 240, 240, 0.49)
	--fg-body	#aaa7a0
	--fg-label	#aaa7a0
	--brand-ink	#8eaeef

Measured against the page, both themes

TOKEN	LIGHT · DARK	
--fg	18.09:1	· 16.57:1
--fg-secondary	8.36:1	· 9.52:1
--fg-muted	4.54:1	· 4.65:1
--fg-body	4.81:1	· 7.86:1
--fg-label	4.52:1	· 7.86:1
--brand-ink	7.01:1	· 8.51:1

The floor is 4.5:1 and two tokens sit on it. --fg-muted measures 4.54:1 in light and --fg-label 4.52:1. That is two hundredths of headroom. Do not lighten either token, and do not darken --bg, without re-running the contrast check.

Four faces, each with one job.

All four are self-hosted at build time. No request leaves this site for a font CDN, which is also why this book can embed the identical files.

Aa

Plus Jakarta Sans

400 500 600

Everything that is read: body copy, labels, controls, the interface. The site's default voice.

Aa

Instrument Serif

400 + italic

Anywhere a person speaks — the name on the plate, guest notes, card headings. Never for UI.

01

Geist Mono

400 700

Every figure. Counters, years, coordinates, the numbering on the greeting. Always tabular.

Aa

Oswald

500 700

Display only, and only where a word is the artwork — the chrome wordmarks. Never as a heading face.

Oswald is condensed and Instrument Serif is not a UI face. Both were put where they are on purpose and both are wrong everywhere else: Oswald at 26px inside a small card reads as a label, and the serif in a button reads as a mistake.

Seven steps, and a floor.

SIZE	WHERE
11px	Labels, counters, notes The label alphabet. Uppercase, 0.14em.
12–13px	Captions, meta, fine print
15–17px	Running copy Body text on a case page sits at 15; 13 is for dense index rows only.
16px	Form fields — minimum Below this iOS Safari zooms the page on focus. Not a preference.
19–26px	Standfirsts, card headings The sentence under a heading, the serif on a note card.
30–38px	Section headings
51–72px	The name, the plate Serif. One per screen, never two.

The label alphabet

One specification, used everywhere a label appears — section labels, plate notes, the hero kicker, the standing facts, the footer heads. It is the most repeated thing on the site and the quickest to drift.

SECTION LABEL 11px · 500 · uppercase · 0.14em · 1.5 · --fg-label

(1) 01 '26 07 Mono · tabular · 700 at full ink for a marker, 400 at --fg-muted for a counter

Smart punctuation throughout: curly quotes, an en dash in ranges, '26 and not 2026 in any row that also carries a name.

Six steps, each twice the one below.

1	4px		inside a line: an icon and its label
2	8px		inside a group: a label and its value
3	16px		between groups
4	32px		between blocks
5	64px		between sub-sections
6	128px		between sections

The one rule about gaps

The gap between two groups must be at least twice the gap inside one.

It is the whole difference between a layout that has air and one that is merely spaced out. A heading 8px from its own line of copy and 12px from the form below does not read as two groups; it reads as one block with nothing in it. That exact fault shipped, was caught by measurement, and is now a check.

The grid

Columns	12
Gutter	24px
Column max	720px
Page gutter, phone	24px

A split section runs its content at 4 / span 7 with the label in the rail beside it. Sub-grids inside a section are allowed to have their own columns — they are not a breach of the twelve.

A rule, not a shadow.

The site separates things with hairlines. Shadow is kept for the two or three objects that are genuinely floating above the page, and a radius is a decision made per object rather than a house style applied to everything.

RADIUS, AS ACTUALLY USED

Photographs, plates, map frames, rules. The default.	0
Small marks and focus rings.	4px
The index row card.	7px
A solid button.	11px
Cards that are objects: note cards, the guest-book card.	14–20px
Only a pill — the sound offer, a tag.	pill

WHERE SHADOW IS ALLOWED

- A dialog over a dimmed page
- A card lifted on hover, 0 to 1 step
- The fan of guest notes — cards on cards
- Nothing else

Depth means *above*. When every box has a shadow, nothing is above anything, and the page has spent its only way of saying so.

Stacking

Any component whose internals need z-index must isolate itself. The guest-note fan deals its cards up to z-index: 100; those numbers mean “in front of the card behind me” and nothing more. Read against the whole document they outranked the dialog at z-50, and a note card landed on top of the form that asks for notes — 40% of it covered, measured. **A component that counts in z-index gets** `isolation: isolate`.

Six things this site is built from.

(1) Index row

A label and a counter over a hairline, then the content, then a hairline and the attribution.

The work index, the note cards, the hero plate card, the greeting plates. One shape, four jobs.

(2) Plate

A picture at full width with a card under it on the page's own surface.

Label and year on a rule, then the serif name or title, then the sentence. Never type over the picture.

(3) Field

A bottom hairline only — a ruled line to write on, not a box to fill in.

16px minimum, placeholder at --fg-muted, the rule goes to --fg on focus.

(4) Solid button

Full-width, --fg on --bg inverted, 11px radius, 13px medium.

One per card. It stays enabled and says what is missing rather than greying out.

(5) Section label

The label alphabet in the rail, with a note under it explaining what the section is.

The note is written to a stranger, not to the author.

(6) Chrome word

A word filled with a sliding greyscale and run through a colour lookup.

Two places only: the greeting and the guest-book card. A third would make it wallpaper.

Motion says something is happening, or it does not happen.

IN USE

- The opening: a count to 100 and a wave wipe, once per session
- The chrome words: a gradient sliding forever, paused off screen
- The greeting plates: one changes every 700ms, round the board
- Reveals: content arriving once, on first sight
- Hover lift: 0 to 1 step, 300ms, the site's own ease

NEVER

- Anything that loops in the corner of the eye while reading
- Parallax
- An entrance that delays reading
- Sound without a tap — the browser forbids it and so does this
- Motion that continues after its section has scrolled away

Two rules, both enforced

Everything animated observes `prefers-reduced-motion`

checked

Everything animated pauses when off screen

`IntersectionObserver`

The opening survives a failed hydration

CSS, not React

The greeting staggers deliberately: one plate at a time, so a plate holds about four seconds and something is always about to move. Six slots on one clock is a strobe. The first attempt flipped all six together because the offset was a no-op, and the check that was supposed to catch it could not fail consistently — a test that cannot fail is not evidence.

A photograph is evidence, so it is captioned and it is not decoration.

Crop	named per image, never centred by default
Edge	1px hairline
Slot shape	fixed aspect-ratio
Alt text	what is in the frame
Caption	drawn from the alt, cut short

The crop is named. A centred cover crop on the isochrone map at 390px landed on empty suburb and cut every branch out of the picture — the one thing the plate existed to show. Each image carries its own object-position.

The slot keeps its shape. Anywhere a picture is replaced — a screensaver slot, a mode switch — the box has a fixed aspect ratio. A landscape frame following a portrait one resizes the page, and a layout that nudges every second is a fault, not an effect.

Nothing is captioned from imagination. Every note on the greeting is its photograph's own alt text cut short, out of `app/data/photography.ts`. A caption written about a picture nobody looked at is a small lie on the front page.

`alt=""` **is an instruction.** It means *ignore this, it is ornament*. Correct for a flourish; wrong for a chart, a screenshot or a photograph.

What this site will not do, and why each one is here.

Every item below was proposed, built or nearly shipped. They are written down because the reason is easy to forget and the thing is easy to do again.

A soft gradient under type on a photograph

The most applied-by-default treatment there is. Measured on the hero direction it came from, the label ran at 2.23:1 against the pale half of the map. A plate does not fade into its label; it has a card under it.

An availability notice

“Open to data roles” puts the whole site in the service of one transaction, dates the moment it stops being true, and makes every project under it read as an application. The site is a logbook, and it holds whether he moves next year or never.

A call to action on the first screen

A page that opens by asking for an introduction is asking before it has shown anything. The ways to reach him are at the end, where someone who wants them will be.

A borrowed palette

Structure can be borrowed from a reference and is. Its colour cannot; it would make that one screen the only place on the site belonging to a different site.

Essays as a condition of publishing

A photograph can go on the site with a caption. Requiring a written piece before anything can be published is a dead end built by hand.

A second alphabet for labels or figures

There is one label specification and one numeric voice. A bold sans figure beside the mono counters is a fourth voice on a page that has one.

Sound that starts on its own

Audible playback needs a tap and iOS Safari has no exception. The record is offered, never imposed, and the offer outlives the opening so it can be noticed.

The parts of this book a script will defend.

Rules that are only written down drift. These run against a production build in a real browser and exit non-zero when they fail.

SCRIPT	WHAT IT HOLDS
verify-contrast	Every text node on the home page, both themes, against WCAG AA.
verify-rhythm	The spacing steps in use. A step used once or twice is an accident.
verify-tap-targets	Standalone controls at 24×24 minimum. Links inside sentences are exempt and not counted.
verify-headings	One h1 per page, no level skipped.
verify-intro	The opening cannot lock anyone out: no JS, no hydration, reduced motion, slow connection.
verify-hallo	The greeting: plate count, numbering, nothing on the word, motion, and no motion under reduce.
verify-guest-note	Nothing paints over the open card; every field is 16px or more.
verify-sound	The record is offered not forced, and carries into the page as one fetch.
verify-chrome-effect	The chrome words actually animate, and freeze under reduce.
verify-photo-viewer	A way out of the gallery that is not the browser's back button.
verify-studio-photos	The gesture that puts a photograph on the site.
audit-seo	Titles, descriptions, canonicals, structured data, orphans, measured layout shift.

A check is only worth what its failure proves. Before a checker is trusted, the fault is put back and the checker is made to fail on it. Several here were written, passed, and were then found to pass on the broken code too — those were rewritten, not kept.

How this book is made.

Generated by `scripts/build-brand-book.mjs`. The colour values are parsed out of `app/globals.css` at build time, the contrast ratios are computed from those values, and the four faces are the same `.woff2` files the site serves, embedded from `.next/static/media`.

Nothing in it was typed from memory, which is the only reason it is worth keeping. Rebuild after any change to the tokens:

```
npm run build && node scripts/build-brand-book.mjs
```

Set in

Plus Jakarta Sans	text, labels
Instrument Serif	headings
Geist Mono	every figure
Oswald	display, on the site

This book describes a site that already exists. Where the two disagree, *the site is right* — and this page tells you how to make the book agree again.